

The original point of view of a Bassanese who has been living in the Swedish capital for 20 years

STOCKHOLM BETWEEN STEREOTYPES AND AUTHENTICITY

It is a very different city from how we normally imagine it from here. To understand it and grasp its soul, one obviously has to live it. The architect Claudio Calderoni, our eclectic and brilliant correspondent, provides us - for the time being - with an initial key to understanding it, taking the opportunity also to address a grateful thought to his unforgettable teacher Sergio Los, who recently passed away.



I call Åsa on the phone. It is dark, it seems late at night but I know it is only autumn, still, I have the feeling that I am invading the intimacy of a person in their home. No waiting with croaking chants or multi-option pre-recorded voices. Softly, the tax agent answers me, calling me by name. I found her number at the foot of the fine for a failure to declare something a bit different from the obvious. I already paid last week, but it says her name, accompanied by her phone number: all for me, should I seek an explanation. Irresistible not to! I confess that I called her out of pure curiosity. She replies that since it is my first time - brace yourself - I get my fine money back! After a few days, the credit arrives with the fussy calculation of the small interest accrued.

Sweden, Italy, paradise, hell... Yet for foreigners, paradise is a place like the *Republic of Bassano*. After almost two decades in Sweden, I too must have become a foreigner, because I leave the house, making my way among the swans, fawns and ducks that populate Stockholm's city centre, and search in vain for the glances of agreement from Lella, behind the counter, who hands me a glass of prosecco *col fondo* (aged on lees), after having chilled the crystal well with disposable ice cubes. Up here on the Scandinavian safari, it doesn't occur to anyone to offer their friends a round. Not because the limb struggles to reach the card, but because it would cost as much as a dinner. One version, as close as possible to that Bassanese counter, has cost me a

laborious search: it is the Sallads-Bar *Strand*, which means *beach*, but on the beach it is not, where Ahmed with a Syrian smile that warms the winters not only serves at the table (a rarity in these parts), but even slices fresh ginger into green tea on request. Then, at the end of the day, he offers lush trays of fruit to my faithful crew of eager for warmth winter swimmers. A warmth that eludes the parade of competitors huddled in the front line on Hornsberg beach, and which is worth conquering by walking a few hundred sparkling steps further into the belly of Stadshagen, the old warehouse district. With that, anyone with an appetite for stereotypes and clichés about algid and reserved but efficient Nordic peoples would be served.

SHARDS

by Claudio Calderoni
correspondent from Stockholm



Above
An image of St Botvid, martyr and evangeliser of Sweden, depicted in the act of clutching an axe in one hand and a fish in the other.

Left side
The sculpture Cirkusarm by the collective LOLA indicates the entrance to Subtopia, clutching a ball in his hand that lights up at night.



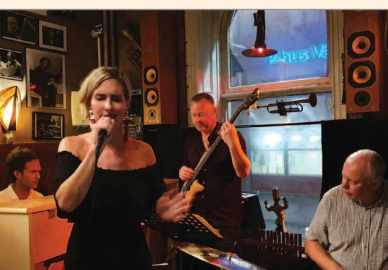
Above (photographer: Andreas Falk)

Architect Claudio Calderoni is not only involved in architecture, but also in education and wellness philosophy. Living in Sweden since 2006, he leads workshops in that country and in Italy on complete somatosensory immersion, with deep roots in the arts and a broad multidisciplinary perspective. Specialising in workshops based on the cultural heritage of places, he addresses leaders and entrepreneurs as well as disadvantaged communities with activities aimed at overcoming hesitation, inertia or resistance. The meetings fuse performing arts, anthropology and science to create connections between body, cultural heritage and local nature. This combination of creativity and exploration of bodily and cognitive potential inspires new perspectives on professional performance, well-being and community building.



Above
Honsberg beach, looking
towards the ancient
Stockholm's ice deposits.

Below, from top to bottom
Claudio Calderoni with his
Assirian friend Ahmed,
manager of the Sallads-Bar
Strand.
The Glenn Miller Café and
the Fasching Jazz Club,
trendy venues in central
Stockholm.



But these days I can't help but hear echoing the voice of my teacher Sergio Los, who would repeat to me that prejudices are the only certainty we have. So, without sadness, I engage with him in this conversation now impossible, or only partly so. Years ago, after various landings between the Engineering Campus and the futuristic premises of the Swedish Internet, I dropped the anchor of my office in the most extravagant place in Stockholm: the headquarters of the circus heart of Scandinavia, a place called Subtopia. It is not even in Stockholm, but on the border of a neighbouring municipality, Botkyrka, named after the missionary Botvid, a saint who holds an axe in one hand and a fish in the other. Not immediately reassuring... but smiling with open arms. Now it's not that my colleagues and I are working under a striped tent with tigers and elephants on the loose, at least not in the strict sense of the word, but under the roof of a kind of cathedral in the shape of a Latin cross, so built by telephone magnate Lars Magnus Ericsson at the beginning of the last century to house happy cows. Evidently exhausted by the trilling of the telephones and encouraged by the successful proselytising to the Vikings of his visionary forerunner, old Ericsson sold all the shares of his empire and, armed with industrious axe and fishy prosperity, he too laid the foundations of a Paradise on Earth: permaculture ante litteram, immaculate milk and Palladian villas amidst woods and lakes.

Replacing the cows and taking over the baton today is us, surrounded by acrobats and clowns. And that *us* is made up of actors, musicians, directors, designers, architects. Now you tell me if the sample of my daily encounters can be considered representative or whether my interpretation of the Swedes can aspire to objectivity. On second thought, however, the Prof. is right and my partisan view is perhaps the more accurate one. Because this is precisely the most authentic Stockholm, the one that breathes life into the city while remaining behind the scenes, the one that lights up theatres and jazz clubs in the city centre like the Glen Miller or the Fasching. And here we are again in the trap - thanks Sergio - praising conformism to the notes of the most reckless jazz. Just like at the end of our interminable conversations, when I regularly discover something new, agree with him and then find myself with a nice paradox to debunk. That's what I usually do: I revise the premise with a walk, possibly on the banks of the river Brenta. But here, in the centre of Stockholm, I have to juggle hundreds of kilometres of shoreline between sea and lake. Never ask what is one or the other, judging by the look, even the ducks seem bewildered. To share my solution to the rebus, however it seems appropriate to wait for the melting ice, which will soon form on the surface of the water. It is truly a lyrical moment, as my dear friend Mats Bergquist, a wonderful artist, now ex-Bassanese and ex-Stockholmer, pointed out years ago when guiding me

through my first winters up here. Narrowing his eyes, partly to gather memories and partly from the smoke of his cigarette, with an inimitable inflection he said something like: 'The bark of the birch trees turns pink, the sea sings with the ice sheets rubbing against each other, and the dark soul of winter gives way to spring'. Then he sadly noted that it is the most poignant time of year, the time when the highest number of suicides occur. It is the 'vemod', he said, a kind of dark and irresistible courage. Just so we don't miss another cliché with a kernel of truth. In order to appreciate the entertainment that the long, dark winter offers, my solution was to relaunch and become more Scandinavian than the Scandinavians. So, together with a neighbour, every morning at six o'clock I descend the stairs harnessed in flip-flops and swimming costume for the daily swim between the wooden jetties and sinuous curves of a body of water known until a century ago to house the city's ice deposits.

Something tells me that the key to unravelling the rebus of bony clichés, a little bit boring, a little bit revealing, has to do with that taking up of the baton handed to us by the cheeky Lars Magnus with his veiled message: 'Let's leave it to the cows to ruminate in neat rows inside the cathedrals. Because we can always choose whether to let ourselves be dragged, somewhat listlessly by a pre-written script, or to be inspired by acrobatics and the sagacious conversations of those who have decided to live intensely.